

INTEGRITY RECORDS

KINGDOMS FOR A SONG

*Resisting the Bargain the Industry
Offers Every Artist*

“All these I will give you, if you will fall down and worship me.”

MATTHEW 4:9

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Resisting the Bargain the Industry Offers Every Artist

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INTRODUCTION

The Bargain Every Artist Is Offered

Every artist who has ever stood in front of a microphone with something true to say has, sooner or later, been offered a version of the same deal. It rarely arrives as a contract clause. More often it arrives as a feeling — a quiet, reasonable-sounding suggestion that the compromise being asked of you is smaller than it looks, and the reward on the other side is bigger than you could reach any other way.

Scripture already told this story, in its most concentrated form, in a single chapter. Before Jesus preached a single sermon or called a single disciple, He was led into the wilderness and tested three times. Each test offered something legitimate — bread, safety, influence — through an illegitimate door.

Then Jesus was led up by the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted by the devil.

MATTHEW 4:1

This book takes those three temptations seriously as a diagnostic tool, not just a devotional memory. Each one maps almost exactly onto a pressure that working musicians face today, particularly Christian artists trying to build a career without leaving their faith at the studio door.

Why this book exists

Integrity Records was built by watching gifted people get talked out of what they actually believed, one small concession at a time. Nobody signs away their convictions all at once. It happens in the same order Satan tried it with Jesus: first meet a need, then perform for validation, then — only once the first two have softened the ground — offer the whole kingdom.

This is not a book about villains. Most people asking artists to compromise are not cartoonishly evil; they are running a business, and the business rewards certain behaviors. The point of this book is not to make you suspicious of every person you work with. It is to make you clear-eyed about which door you are being invited through, so you can recognize a familiar test before you are standing in the middle of it.

How to use this book

- Read the three temptation chapters in order — they build on each other, the way the original temptations did.
- Use the reflection boxes honestly. They are for you, not for anyone else to see.
- Keep Chapter Five nearby the next time you are actually reviewing a contract.

REFLECTION

Has a compromise ever come to you disguised as something reasonable — even necessary?

What did it promise to solve, and did solving it actually require what was asked?

CHAPTER ONE

Bread from Stones

If you are the Son of God, command these stones to become loaves of bread.

MATTHEW 4:3

The first temptation is aimed at the most defensible need a person can have: hunger. Jesus had fasted forty days. He was not tempted to steal, or to harm anyone, or to do anything that looks obviously wrong on its face. He was tempted to use His identity and power for Himself, on His own timetable, instead of trusting the Father's provision.

This is where compromise almost always enters an artist's life first — not through a scandal, but through a genuinely hard season. Rent is due. A label offers an advance with terms that quietly sign away ownership of the masters. A sync deal wants the song attached to a message the artist doesn't actually believe, but the check clears the same day it's needed. None of these moments feel like a betrayal of faith. They feel like solving a real problem the fastest available way.

The subtle lie inside a true need

The temptation is not that hunger is imaginary. Jesus really was hungry. The lie is the implied timeline: that the need is too urgent to wait for a provision that doesn't require compromising who you are. Every predatory deal in the music industry is built to feel more urgent than it actually is — because urgency is what makes people skip the questions they would otherwise ask.

- A deal that requires an answer “today or it's off the table” is using urgency as a tool, not a fact.
- A need that is real does not automatically make every solution to it acceptable.
- Provision that requires you to become someone else is not provision — it's a trade.

What this looks like in practice

A songwriter is offered a work-for-hire arrangement that pays quickly but forfeits all future royalties and any say in how the song is used — including uses the writer would never have agreed to if asked directly. A worship artist is offered festival slots contingent on adding material with no spiritual content, marketed as “just business, not a statement of belief.” A vocalist is told the label will “take care of everything” in exchange for signing away the rights to their own name and likeness.

In each case, a legitimate need — income, exposure, stability — is used as leverage to extract something the artist would not give away if there were no pressure attached.

REFLECTION

What need in your own life has felt urgent enough to make a compromise seem reasonable?

If money were not a factor at all, would you still take this particular deal?

CHAPTER TWO

The Edge of the Temple

If you are the Son of God, throw yourself down, for it is written, 'He will command his angels concerning you.'

MATTHEW 4:6

The second temptation is stranger than the first, because it is dressed in scripture. Satan quotes Psalm 91 back to Jesus, inviting Him to force God's hand publicly — to manufacture a moment of spectacle and call it faith. The temple's pinnacle was, notably, one of the most visible points in Jerusalem. This was never a private test. It was staged for an audience.

This is the temptation of manufactured spectacle: the pressure to create a moment — a scandal, a stunt, a controversy, a viral risk — and dress it up as boldness, prophetic courage, or simply “letting God work.” It is the temptation to test whether faithfulness will be rewarded with attention, rather than trusting that faithfulness is worth something on its own.

Attention is not the same as calling

The music industry runs on attention the way a car runs on fuel, and there is enormous pressure — sometimes from labels, sometimes from an artist's own anxious heart — to generate it artificially. A carefully timed public statement. A manufactured feud. A song deliberately engineered to offend just enough people to trend. Each of these can be defended afterward as “starting a conversation” or “being authentic,” but the test underneath is the same one offered at the temple: will you throw yourself into a spectacle and trust that God — or the algorithm — will catch you?

- Manufactured controversy that happens to align with an album release is worth examining honestly.
- Genuine conviction sometimes does create controversy — but it doesn't need to be engineered to “work.”
- If a moment only makes sense as a marketing calendar entry, it is probably not a matter of faith.

The quieter version

Not every version of this temptation is dramatic. It can be as small as writing a lyric you don't actually believe because it will “perform well,” or timing a public apology or public grievance for maximum reach rather than out of genuine repentance or need. The test is not whether the audience notices. The test is whether the act was done for God or done for the algorithm wearing God's name.

REFLECTION

Has ambition ever pushed you to manufacture a moment rather than simply live faithfully and let attention come or not come?

What would it look like to trust that faithfulness is enough, even without a guaranteed audience?

CHAPTER THREE

All the Kingdoms of the World

All these I will give you, if you will fall down and worship me.

MATTHEW 4:9

The first two temptations were softening blows. The third is the real offer, and it is breathtaking in its honesty: total influence, total reach, total kingdoms — in exchange for one act of worship pointed in the wrong direction. Satan does not pretend the kingdoms aren't real. He does not lie about what is on the table. He simply asks for everything in return.

This is the temptation the first two exist to prepare an artist for. Once a need has been met through compromise, and a public identity has been built on manufactured moments rather than conviction, the final ask rarely feels like a shocking betrayal. It feels like the natural next step — a bigger deal, a bigger platform, a bigger version of choices already made. The soul is not usually sold in one dramatic transaction. It is sold in installments, and the final installment simply completes a pattern the earlier ones already established.

What 'worship' looks like in a record deal

Nobody is handed a literal altar. The modern version of this temptation looks like a deal that requires an artist to stop naming Christ publicly because it “limits the brand,” or a contract that gives a label final creative control over lyrical content indefinitely, or a career track that requires quietly repositioning faith as a private hobby rather than the center of the work. The kingdoms on offer are genuinely large — genuine platforms, genuine wealth, genuine cultural reach. That is precisely what makes this temptation dangerous: the payoff is not fake.

- The size of the platform being offered has no bearing on whether the price is worth paying.
- A deal that requires silence about what you actually believe is asking for worship, whatever language it uses.
- Influence gained by compromising conviction is rarely available to be un-compromised later.

Why this one is the hardest to see

The first temptation is disguised as need. The second is disguised as boldness. The third barely needs a disguise, because by the time it arrives, the artist has often already practiced saying yes to smaller versions of the same trade. Recognizing this temptation requires looking honestly at the pattern of the first two — because the third rarely shows up out of nowhere.

REFLECTION

Where has success already required you to grow quieter about what you believe?

If the offer in front of you were ten times smaller, would you still be considering it?

CHAPTER FOUR

How He Answered

What is easy to miss in the temptation narrative is that Jesus never argued with Satan's premises. He didn't deny He was hungry. He didn't deny the kingdoms were real or that Satan had genuine authority to offer them (Luke's account even implies Satan's claim of authority was not disputed). He answered every single test the same way — not with a clever counter-argument, but with Scripture already hidden in Him before the wilderness began.

Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that comes from the mouth of God.

MATTHEW 4:4

You shall not put the Lord your God to the test.

MATTHEW 4:7

You shall worship the Lord your God and him only shall you serve.

MATTHEW 4:10

Each answer came from Deuteronomy — words Jesus had internalized long before the wilderness. This detail matters more than it first appears. He was not improvising theology under pressure. He was retrieving conviction that had already been settled.

The discipline of deciding in advance

This is the practical heart of resisting these same three tests as an artist: the decisions cannot be made for the first time in the room where the offer is made. An artist who has never thought through what they would say no to will find every argument for saying yes persuasive in the moment, because urgency and flattery are both designed to short-circuit reflection.

- Decide, before you need the money, what kind of deal you will not take regardless of the number attached.
- Decide, before the platform is offered, what you will not stay silent about to keep it.
- Write these decisions down. A conviction that only exists in your head is easier to renegotiate under pressure than one you've already put into words.

Fasting, not scarcity

It's worth noticing Jesus was tested at His most physically depleted moment, not His strongest. The forty-day fast was not incidental to the story — it was preparation, not merely deprivation. There's a difference between a spiritual discipline that trains you to depend on God before you're tested, and simply arriving at a hard season with no reserves and hoping conviction will hold. The first is preparation. The second is just wishful thinking.

REFLECTION

What convictions have you settled in advance, before you needed them?

What decision could you make today, in a calm season, that would protect you in a harder one?

CHAPTER FIVE

Reading a Contract Like Scripture

Conviction matters, but conviction still has to be applied to actual paper. Many artists who would never consciously choose to compromise their faith have still ended up in exactly that position, because the compromise was written into clauses they didn't fully understand until years later. This chapter is deliberately practical.

Ownership of masters

The master recording is the actual property that gets licensed, sold, and streamed. Whoever owns the masters controls where and how a song can be used indefinitely — including uses the original artist might never have agreed to. Before signing anything, know specifically who will own the masters, for how long, and under what conditions — if any — ownership might revert to the artist.

Creative control clauses

Look specifically for language about approval rights over lyrical content, themes, or public statements. A clause that gives a label or publisher unilateral final say over content — without a floor protecting the artist's core convictions — is, functionally, the third temptation written into a legal document.

Morality and 'brand alignment' clauses

Some contracts include clauses allowing a label to terminate or restrict an artist over vaguely defined “brand alignment” concerns. These can be used neutrally, but they can also become a tool to quietly pressure an artist away from public statements of faith once fame makes that faith “commercially inconvenient.” Ask directly what would trigger this clause, and get specifics in writing rather than a verbal reassurance.

Urgency clauses and deadlines

A genuinely good deal rarely requires a decision within 24 hours. Artificial urgency is one of the oldest tools for preventing careful review — including review by a lawyer who isn't emotionally invested in the deal closing.

- Never sign anything the same day it's presented, regardless of the pressure applied.
- Have a qualified entertainment attorney review anything involving masters, publishing, or long-term exclusivity — this is not optional caution, it's basic protection.
- Ask what happens if you want out in three years. A deal that has no honest answer to that question is not a safe deal.

REFLECTION

Have you ever signed something without fully understanding a clause, because the moment felt too urgent to slow down?

Who is one person you trust who could review a contract with you before you sign — not after?

CHAPTER SIX

Building an Identity the Industry Can't Buy

Underneath all three temptations is a single deeper question: where does your sense of who you are actually come from? If identity is built on streaming numbers, chart positions, or industry approval, every one of these temptations will feel unavoidable eventually, because the whole structure of identity depends on winning the industry's approval to survive.

An identity that doesn't need the deal

Jesus could resist the offer of “all the kingdoms of the world” specifically because His identity was never dependent on ruling them. That security had already been spoken over Him at His baptism — “this is my beloved Son” — before He had done a single public thing to earn it. The security came first. The temptation came after, and had nothing left to attach to.

An artist whose sense of worth is anchored somewhere the industry cannot touch — in being known and loved by God prior to any success — is simply harder to tempt with success, because success was never the thing holding them together in the first place.

Practical anchors

- Maintain relationships and accountability outside the industry — people who knew you before any of this and will tell you the truth.
- Keep a spiritual practice that has nothing to do with your career: prayer, scripture, worship that isn't being recorded or performed.
- Regularly revisit why you started making music in the first place, in writing, and compare it honestly to where you are now.
- Build enough financial margin, however modest, that a bad offer doesn't feel like the only option available.

A note on community

Isolation makes every one of these three temptations more effective. Satan tested Jesus alone, in the wilderness, away from the crowds who had followed Him and the disciples He would soon call. Artists facing real pressure to compromise are far more vulnerable doing it in isolation than in genuine community with other believers who can name what's actually happening in the moment it's happening.

REFLECTION

Where does your sense of worth actually come from right now — be honest?

Who in your life would tell you the truth if they saw you starting down this path?

CHAPTER SEVEN

After the Wilderness

Then the devil left him, and behold, angels came and were ministering to him.

MATTHEW 4:11

The temptation narrative doesn't end with the third refusal. It ends with provision — angels ministering to Jesus in the same wilderness where He had just been tested. The lesson is not that resisting temptation earns a reward. It's that the provision Satan offered falsely in the first temptation was there all along, available on legitimate terms, the moment Jesus stopped looking for a shortcut to it.

This is worth sitting with, because resisting these three temptations as an artist does not guarantee an easier career. Some doors that would have opened through compromise will simply stay closed. But the promise embedded in this passage is not the absence of hardship — it's that faithfulness is not abandoned to figure things out alone in the wilderness indefinitely.

What faithfulness actually costs

It would be dishonest to promise that resisting these temptations leads reliably to greater fame or fortune. Sometimes it does. Often it means a smaller platform, a slower career, or opportunities that go to someone willing to make the trade you weren't. This book will not pretend otherwise. What it will say plainly is that the version of success available through compromise was never actually the kingdom it claimed to be — Satan was offering something he could deliver temporarily, dressed as something permanent.

A different measure of success

Integrity Records exists on the conviction that a smaller, honest career is worth more than a larger, compromised one — not as a consolation, but as the actual better outcome, measured on a longer timeline than a single lifetime allows us to fully see.

REFLECTION

What would it look like for you to define success on different terms than the industry does?

What has faithfulness already cost you — and where have you seen provision meet you in it anyway?

CLOSING WORD

The Kingdoms Were Never His to Give

It is worth ending where the temptation narrative quietly undercuts itself: Satan offered Jesus “all the kingdoms of the world,” but Scripture is clear elsewhere that all authority in heaven and on earth already belonged to Christ, and would be given to Him in full after the resurrection — freely, without any bowing required. The temptation was never really about whether Jesus would gain influence. It was about whether He would take a shortcut to something that was already coming to Him on righteous terms.

The same is often true for artists weighing a compromise. The version of success on offer through the shortcut is rarely as exclusive as it's made to feel. What's actually being tested is patience, and trust that the long way is not the same as the losing way.

If you take nothing else from this book, take this: decide now, before you are hungry, before the platform is dangled, before the kingdoms are named — what you will not trade. Write it down. Tell someone. And when the wilderness comes, as it does for every artist eventually, you will already know the answer.

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